When properties lend themselves to events: deriving responsibility in English middles

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tldr

Middles encode a primitive semantic relation (Lend) between surface subject properties and events

- a property-to-event connection that is asserted, not pragmatically inferred
- states the surface subject (due to its properties) *lends itself* to the unfolding of the event named by the verb.

Introduction

The English middle construction:

- Surface form resembles passives/unaccusative but behaves differently
- Surface subject interpreted as logical object (Theme/Patient/Experiencer)
- Implicit external argument is entailed

(1) a. This bread cuts easily
b. Politicians bribe readily.
c. Small children frighten quickly.

Middles typically need some sort of *additional* modification/material:

(2) a. ??This bread cuts
b. This bread cuts **easily** — *manner adverb*
c. This bread does/will **not** cut. — *negation*
d. **THIS** bread cuts. — *contrastive focus*
e. **Properly tempered** steel cuts. — *subject modification*
f. **When heated to 200° C**, this blade steel cuts. — *adjunct clause*

The Core Puzzle

1. Why do "facilitators" improve middle formation across different structural positions?
2. Why are surface subject properties so crucial to middle formation?

Preview of proposal

Building on Williams 2015: Surface subject *properties* must be **explanatorily responsible** for event feasibility.

- **Claim**: Responsibility attribution in middles is semantically encoded via a middle head (m) that introduces a primitive Lend relation.
- "Facilitators" help make the property-to-event relation more salient.

Surface subject properties matter

What about the surface subject contributes to a well-formed middle?

Early claims: Affectedness constraint (Roberts 1987; Fagan 1988)

- Only affected themes/patients can appear as middle subjects
- Theme must undergo change of state as result of the event

Against affectedness constraints (see also Bruening 2024; Ackema and Schoorlemmer 1994)

(3) *Unaffected subjects in middles*
a. El Capitan climbs slowly.
b. This aria sings beautifully.
c. Long trucks do not pass easily. (Bruening 2024, 82b)

Property relevance

- Canonical middles: surface subject properties are inherently relevant

(4) a. This bread cuts easily. (texture, density, freshness → easy to cut)
b. Politicians bribe easily. (moral character, greed → can be bribed)
c. Small children frighten easily. (vulnerability, sensitivity → easy to frighten)

Key observation: Surface subject must have properties relevant to the event's unfolding, but need not be affected.

- Context can make marginal examples acceptable

(5) a. ?This desk kicks easily. (out of the blue)
b. [Context: *Biomechanics lab testing boxing glove sensors that need large targets. Mike's face is small, so he's not a good candidate. Paul's face, however, is huge.*]
» **Paul's face punches easily/better than Mike's.**

- Surface subject's **intrinsic design properties** can directly facilitate the event

(6) a. This dress buttons up. (has buttons → designed for buttoning)
b. This pole extends. (has lengthening mechanism → designed for extending)

Generalization: Middle subjects must have properties that are explanatorily relevant to the event's realization

Facilitation is structurally distributed

Facilitators occur at distinct structural positions; not a unified syntactic requirement (contra Newman 2020)

Subject-oriented facilitators:

- Make the surface subject referentially specific or its properties salient
- Include definiteness, quantification, focus, modification, adjunct clauses

(7) *Subject-oriented*
a. *A guy / ✓a dictator will bribe. — *definiteness/specificity/kinds*
b. Every/no politician bribed yesterday. — *quantifier*
c. THIS guy will bribe. — *contrastive focus*
d. A corrupt politician with weak morals will bribe. — *subject modification*
e. When offered extra perks, a politician will bribe. — *adjunct clause*

Event-oriented facilitators:

- Specify manner, degree, or conditions under which the event unfolds
- Crucially: NO access to agent's mental state (volitional adverbs banned)

(8) *Eventuality modifiers*
a. This leather punctures **easily/readily/smoothly**. — ✓ *manner adverb*
b. This text translates **poorly/perfectly/well**. — ✓ *degree of perfection adverb*
c. These screws remove quickly **with a power drill**. — ✓ *instrumental PP*
d. Banks rob more easily **with a getaway driver**. — ✓ *comitative PP*
e. *This bread cuts **deliberately/carefully**. — ✗ *volitional adverb*

Extended projection facilitators include **negation** and **aspect**

(9) *Extended verbal projection*
a. This leather will not puncture. — *negation*
b. Finally, the leather is puncturing now. — *aspect*

Key observation: Facilitators target various distinct structural domains

Generalization: *ALL* facilitators serve to establish connection between subject properties and event realization

- Subject-oriented facilitators: make relevant properties salient/accessible
- Event-oriented facilitators: specify conditions on how properties enable the event

Upshot: The heterogeneity of facilitators suggests that middle formation depends on establishing a clear *semantic* relationship (property→event) rather than satisfying a single syntactic requirement

Responsibility in middles

Williams (2015): Reason clause control tracks the Responsible Party (RP)

- RP = the party explanatorily responsible for the target fact

(10) (Williams 2015, (85), (89), (91))
a. The ewe was killed [PRO to gain the blessings of Apollo]. (passive)
→ RP = killer; PRO controlled by implicit agent
b. *Ewes kill easily [PRO to survive the winter]. (middle)
→ RP ≠ killer; implicit agent cannot control PRO
c. This harness adjusts easily [PRO to fit many torsos]. (middle)
→ RP = harness (properties); surface subject controls PRO

In passives: RP = implicit agent (typically)

(11) a. The text was translated poorly. (RP = translator; RP ≠ the text)
b. Texts assigned to that lab are translated poorly. (RP = translators; RP ≠ the text)

In middles: RP = surface subject (properties); never implicit agent

(12) a. The text translated poorly. (RP = the text; RP ≠ translators)
b. Texts assigned to that lab translate poorly. (RP = texts assigned to that lab; RP ≠ translators)

Biggs and Embick 2022: In passives, responsibility is pragmatically derived

Responsibility is entailed in middles

In middles, responsibility attribution to surface subject is:
(i) non-cancelable, (13a); (ii) invariable, (13b); and (iii) context-independent, (13c).

(13) a. This text translated easily, #but nothing about its properties made that possible. — RP = this text
b. This bread cuts easily, #though it's actually the knife's sharpness that matters. — RP = this bread
c. This dress buttons up. — RP = this dress

Upshot: Middles semantically encode property-to-event responsibility; passives derive it pragmatically

External Arguments

Some claim only predicates with agentive external arguments (Bruening 2024; Ackema and Schoorlemmer 1994)
But **causers** work too (as noted by Fagan (1988)):

- Non-agentive psych predicates form middles, (14a, b); cf. predicates without initiators, (14c, d)

(14) a. Teenagers embarrass easily at that age. (implicit causer)
b. Small children frighten easily. (implicit causer)
c. *French learns easily. (no implicit causer)
d. *Pain doesn't feel easily. (Bruening 2024, (81)) (no implicit causer)

Provisional generalization: Middles require implicit initiators (agents OR causers), not just agents

External arguments are entailed

Predicates that participate in the causative/inchoative alternation are ambiguous

- Agent-denying continuations force unaccusative reading:

(15) a. The balloon popped, but no one popped it. (unaccusative)
b. The door opened, but no one opened it. (unaccusative)

- Instrumental PPs force middle reading (initiator required):

(16) a. The balloon popped easily with a pin, #but nothing/no one popped it. (middle)
b. The door opened quickly with a crowbar, #but nothing/no one opened it. (middle)

- Cf. pure unaccusative w/o causative alternate.

(17) a. The old man died quickly, but nothing caused him to die.
b. The leaves fell quickly, but nothing caused them to fall.

Upshot: Middles entail implicit initiator (agent OR causer); motivates **Voice** projection

Proposal

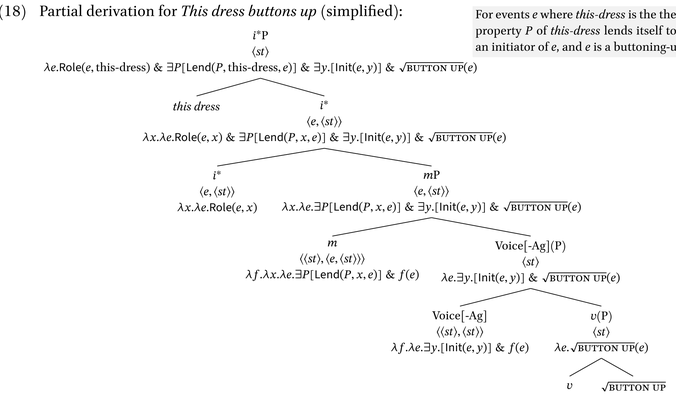
A middle head m establishes a semantic relation (Lend) between surface subject properties and the event.

Key architectural features:

- **Voice** introduces implicit initiator and existentially binds it; semantically entailed, not syntactically projected
- **Middle head** (m) introduces the Lend relation: $[\![m]\!] = \lambda f_{\langle s,t\rangle}\lambda x.\lambda e.\exists P[\mathsf{Lend}(P, x, e)]\ \&\ f(e)$
  → Encodes explanatory responsibility as part of assertion (not implicature)
  → Requires surface subject properties to facilitate event realization (distinct from *causation*)
- **Generalized argument introducer** (i^*) places surface subject origin high in the structure:
  → i^* receives thematic interpretation contextually (Wood and Marantz 2017; Biggs and Embick 2025)
  → Surface subject not a verbal complement (cf. Bruening 2024)
  → **Challenge:** ensuring the correct theta-role despite external merge above m

(18) Partial derivation for *This dress buttons up* (simplified):

For events e where *this-dress* is the theme, some property P of *this-dress* lends itself to e, there's an initiator of e, and e is a buttoning-up event.



Note: No generic/modal operator required in middle; independent generic operator *can* occur higher in clause

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